
PROPHET ILYAS / ELIJAH: HE ARRIVES ALREADY SPEAKING

Every verse that touches him, arranged as a single life

RECONSTRUCTED BIOGRAPHY

What the record carries, and the map of what it withholds

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ABSTRACT. Every verse of the anchor corpus that touches Ilyas AS, swept, halo-expanded to its immediate context, sequenced by narrative-internal chronology under printed warrants, and rendered as one continuous life with the scripture verbatim as the spine. The connective prose is visibly subordinate throughout and never merges with the scripture inside a sentence, so that stripping every regular-weight word leaves a citable text. Interiority renders only where the corpus reports it. Gaps are declared rather than bridged. The Quranic account runs as a labelled parallel branch and is never merged into the Hebrew arc. The artifact closes on a ledger of every verse used and a Silence Map of what the corpus refuses to supply, which in this case includes the birth, the lineage, the call, the household, the death, and the grave.

KEYWORDS *attestation sweep · context halo · sequence lock · two-register visual contract · attested interiority · gap declaration · divergence branch · Silence Map · life-scope seal*

I. MOVEMENT ONE · THE ATTESTATION SWEEP

Reading policy. All renderings below are this instrument's own, made against the Hebrew and the Arabic with the public-domain versions held as control. No single modern translation is reproduced. Scripture prints bold and carries its citation. Connective prose prints regular. The two never merge inside a sentence.

Census, anchor corpus HB, canonical order.

NAMED. 1 Kings 17:1 to 17:24. 1 Kings 18:1 to 18:46. 1 Kings 19:1 to 19:21. 1 Kings 21:17 to 21:29. 2 Kings 1:3 to 1:17. 2 Kings 2:1 to 2:18. 2 Kings 9:36. 2 Kings 10:10. 2 Kings 10:17. 2 Chronicles 21:12. Malachi 3:23.

TITLED. *ish ha-Elohim*, man of God, at 1 Kings 17:18, 17:24, and repeatedly at 2 Kings 1:9 to 1:13. *adoni*, my lord, on Obadiah's tongue at 1 Kings 18:7. *avi*, my father, on Elisha AS's at 2 Kings 2:12. The gentilic *ha-Tishbi* travels with the name and is not a separate class.

ADDRESSED. Divine speech directed to him at 1 Kings 17:2, 17:8, 18:1, 19:9, 19:11, 19:13, 19:15, 21:17, 21:28, 2 Kings 1:3, and 2 Kings 1:15. Eleven commissions, and the count matters: this is a figure the corpus renders overwhelmingly as a recipient of orders and a deliverer of them.

UNNAMED-IDENTIFIED, admitted only with a stated identification warrant, and never carrying a claim alone. Malachi 3:1, the messenger who prepares the way, which the same book names four verses from its end but does not name here. Marked, fenced, and carried only where the naming at 3:23 supports it.

Total. One hundred and fifty-seven verses across seven books, of which roughly one hundred and forty-six are narrative and the remainder are fulfilment notices and forward promise. This is a dense attestation by the standards of the corpus, and the density is what makes a continuous life assemblable at all. The count is reported before the narration because the reader is entitled to know which kind of artifact they are holding.

Parallel corpus QUR. NAMED at Q 6:85 and Q 37:123. The vignette runs Q 37:123 to 37:132. Eleven verses. No TITLED, no ADDRESSED, no UNNAMED-IDENTIFIED. This runs as a branch under and is not merged.

2. MOVEMENT TWO · THE CONTEXT HALO

Each biographical block expanded outward to its pericope boundary, with the function of each halo unit marked.

SETTING for the eruption. 1 Kings 16:29 to 16:34, the reign notice for Ahab, the Sidonian marriage, the Baal temple raised in Samaria, the Asherah, and Hiel rebuilding Jericho at the price of two sons. Without this halo the first words of Ilyas AS have no addressee and no stakes. With it, they are a strike at a state cult installed by treaty within the previous decade.

CAUSE for Carmel. 1 Kings 18:4 and 18:19, the hundred prophets hidden in caves and the eight hundred and fifty at the queen's table, which establish the persecution and the payroll simultaneously.

CONSEQUENCE for the vineyard sentence. 1 Kings 22:34 to 22:38, the arrow at random, the blood washed in the pool of Samaria, and the dogs. Then, long after the departure, 2 Kings 9:36 to 9:37, 10:10, and 10:17, three fulfilment notices in which the corpus audits his word against events by naming him.

SPEECH-FRAME. The divine commissions at 1 Kings 17:2, 17:8, 18:1, 19:15, 21:17, 21:28, and 2 Kings 1:3, each of which converts what follows from initiative into instruction. This is a structural fact about the figure and it cuts against the popular image: he is sent far more often than he moves.

FORMULA. The Kings regnal frame, which closes every reign with a burial notice, a place, and a successor. Its absence at the one place it should appear is treated in the Silence Map.

SERIES-FRAME, parallel corpus. Q 37:119 to 37:122, the closing quatrain of the Musa AS and Harun AS vignette, identical in structure to the quatrain that closes his own at Q 37:129 to 37:132. The Quranic account's brevity is a property of the series, not a gap in it.

3. MOVEMENT THREE · THE SEQUENCE LOCK

The Hebrew material arrives already in narrative order inside Kings, which is unusual and which is recorded here rather than assumed. Warrants printed on every join in the rendition below. Three units do not take a place in the arc and are held out of it.

Held out, unit one. The letter to Jehoram of Judah, 2 Chronicles 21:12 to 21:15. Jehoram of Judah reigns after the point at which Kings places the departure. A written oracle from Ilyas AS to a king who is reigning after he is taken is a genuine tension internal to the corpus, and three readings are live: the letter was written before the departure and delivered later, Kings places the departure non-chronologically, or the Chronicler has constructed the letter. Nothing in either text decides it. The unit is held out of the arc, printed whole in its own section, and the tension is named rather than resolved.

Held out, unit two. The Quranic vignette. It supplies no sequencing marker of any kind. Mapping it onto Carmel by shared antagonist is an identification and not a sequence, so under it runs as a parallel branch rather than as an insertion.

FORWARD. Malachi 3:23 to 3:24. Not a biographical unit. It stands after the life and outside it, and it is printed as a terminal forward-unit.

4. THE LIFE · I. THE WORLD BEFORE HE SPEAKS

The halo, not yet the man.

Ahab son of Omri became king over Israel in Samaria and reigned twenty-two years. And Ahab son of Omri did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD, more than all who were before him. And it was a light thing for him to walk in the sins of Jeroboam son of Nebat, so he took as wife Jezebel daughter of Ethbaal king of the Sidonians, and went and served Baal and bowed to him. He raised an altar for Baal in the house of Baal, which he built in Samaria. And Ahab made the Asherah. (1 Kgs 16:29-33)

[Halo function: SETTING. The cult is imported, dynastic, and recent, and it is housed in a purpose-built temple in the capital.]

In his days Hiel the Bethelite rebuilt Jericho. He laid its foundation at the cost of Abiram his firstborn, and set up its gates at the cost of Segub his youngest, according to the word of the LORD which he spoke by Joshua son of Nun. (1 Kgs 16:34)

[Halo function: SETTING. The corpus places a fulfilled prophetic word immediately before the entrance, which is how it announces the register the next verse will operate in.]

BOX | A STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE WORLD THE PROPHET ENTERS

Rain is Baal's profession, not one attribute among several. This is the technical fact the whole cycle turns on, and without it the announcement at 17:1 reads as a weather prediction. In the Ugaritic corpus recovered at Ras Shamra, Baal Haddu is the storm. His voice is thunder, his weapons are the lightning shaft and the mace, his palace is finished only when a window is opened so that he can thunder through it, and when Mot swallows him the rains fail and the furrows wither, while his return is announced by heavens raining oil and wadis running with honey. Rain is the index of whether he is alive or swallowed. A multi-year drought announced in his own court is therefore a public failure by a named specialist in his single advertised competence.

A further precision cuts against the easy reading. That same corpus already contains a drought sequence and already explains it: Baal is not incompetent, he is swallowed and will return. The Tyrian side of the court had a complete theological account of a long drought available. The contest was never over whether the rains could fail. It was over whose withholding it was and whose word would end it, which is a dispute about jurisdiction rather than an argument from anomaly, and that is why it eventually requires a public adjudication rather than an argument.

The cult arrives by a named route, in a named generation. Jezebel is daughter of Ethbaal king of the Sidonians, and the marriage is a treaty instrument of an ordinary kind. Tyre is an island city with a maritime economy, timber and craft exports, and a chronic deficit in grain and oil; the Jezreel and coastal plains are among the best cereal ground in the southern Levant. Israel supplies food and a land corridor, Tyre supplies craft, capital, and access to the Mediterranean network. A royal wife brings her household cult because that is what such a marriage is. So the Baal who appears in Samaria is not a folk survival. He is the religious clause of the kingdom's most valuable foreign contract.

Prophecy in this world was a salaried profession, and this is the fact modern readers most reliably miss. The Mari archive, five centuries earlier, documents court prophets delivering divine messages to the palace with their reports filed, their credentials checked by a lock of hair and a hem of garment sent with the tablet, and their maintenance carried as a palace expense. The system is administrative. In the Hebrew corpus's own account of this reign, four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and four hundred of Asherah eat at the queen's table, and that phrase is a budget line rather than a metaphor. Four chapters after Carmel, four hundred court prophets perform with iron horns and return the answer the king commissioned, against one dissenter the king says he hates because the dissenter never brings good news.

That is the baseline against which everything in this life should be read. Prophecy here is a court function, paid, credentialed, and answerable to the payer, and its products behave accordingly. The ravens and the widow are not pious colour. They are the structural inverse of an institution.

5. THE LIFE · II. THE ERUPTION

He is not introduced. There is no birth notice, no father, no call, no vision, and no commissioning scene. The corpus gives a gentile, a region, and a sentence already in progress.

And Elijah the Tishbite, of the settlers of Gilead, said to Ahab: As the LORD lives, the God of Israel before whom I stand, there shall be no dew nor rain these years except by my word. (1 Kgs 17:1)

[Sequencing warrant: *EXPLICIT* by position. The clause follows 16:34 with no transitional formula and no preparatory scene.]

That is the entire biographical apparatus the corpus supplies at his entrance, and two of its three elements are uncertain: Tishbe is unlocated and the phrase rendered here as *of the settlers* is contested in the ancient versions. What he claims in this first sentence is standing, *before whom I stand*, which is the courtier's term for attendance on a king, and a condition, *except by my word*.

BOX | B STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE NAME, AND THE MAN WITH NO FATHER

The gentilic, dug. The consonants are תִּשְׁבֵּי, and four roads are live. The strongest is textual rather than etymological. The verse pairs *ha-Tishbī* with *mi-tōshābē*, and *tōshāb* is the technical term at Leviticus 25:23 for a resident alien dwelling on land that is not his patrimony. The two words sit in near-assonance in a single clause, and the ancient versions already diverge on how to read the second, which suggests the tradition was itself unsure whether it held a place or a status. On that reading he is introduced as the resident alien from among the resident aliens. The second road is a place: a Tishbe of Naphtali appears in Tobit, but Naphtali is not Transjordan and the datum pulls against the verse it would explain, and no Transjordanian Tishbe has been identified. The third is the root sh-w-b, to turn or return, which is morphologically weakest and is attractive precisely because the last verse of the prophetic canon makes his function to turn hearts, so the attraction is itself the warning. The fourth, a root meaning captivity, is thin. The wordplay reading is strongest because it lies inside the verse rather than outside it. Secure on any road: he is introduced by a status or an origin and never by a father.

No patronymic, and the omission is unique among the major prophets. Isaiah AS is given ben Amoz, Jeremiah AS ben Hilkiah, Ezekiel AS ben Buzi, Hosea ben Beerī. He is given a town that cannot be located and a region. The Letter to the Hebrews built an entire argument out of a comparable silence around Melchizedek, converting an absent genealogy into positive theological claim, and the comparison is apt at the entrance. It has an exact limit. Melchizedek has no exit either, which is the whole of that argument's force, whereas this prophet has a narrated departure with a chariot, fifty witnesses at a distance, and a three-day search. The type holds at the entrance and gives way at the exit, and what does the work there is the withheld burial formula, treated at the departure.

The office, stated from inside by its clearest later holder. A century after, Amos comes from Tekoa in the southern hills to the royal sanctuary at Bethel, and the priest expels him with a sentence that is unmistakably about money: go back to Judah, eat bread there, and prophesy there. The accusation is that he is a jobbing prophet working a foreign market. The answer denies salary and guild in one breath: I was no prophet nor a prophet's son, I was a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs. The phrase rendered prophet's son is the guild term. That is the office described from within by the next man to hold it, in the same kingdom, and it is the strongest indication that what began here was a structural position rather than a personal style.

One term inside the verse. *Lifnav amadti*, before whom I stand, is the courtier's idiom for attendance on a king. His first sentence claims a post in one court while addressing the holder of another.

6. THE LIFE · III. CHERITH, AND THE FOREIGN WIDOW

And the word of the LORD came to him: Go from here, turn eastward, and hide yourself by the wadi Cherith, which is opposite the Jordan. You shall drink from the wadi, and I have commanded the ravens to sustain you there. So he went and did according to the word of the LORD, and he went and stayed by the wadi Cherith opposite the Jordan. And the ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning and bread and meat in the evening, and he drank from the wadi. (1 Kgs 17:2-6)

[Sequencing warrant: EXPLICIT. The commission follows the declaration directly.]

The drought he announced does not exempt him.

And after a time the wadi dried up, because there was no rain in the land. (1 Kgs 17:7)

[Gap declaration: the text gives after a time and no duration.]

And the word of the LORD came to him: Arise, go to Zarephath which belongs to Sidon, and stay there. See, I have commanded a widow there to sustain you. (1 Kgs 17:8-9)

He is sent into the home territory of the queen who will later seek his life, and into the economic zone of the treaty partner whose god he has just challenged. The corpus does not comment on this and the connective register will not supply the comment.

So he arose and went to Zarephath. And he came to the entrance of the town, and there was a widow gathering sticks. And he called to her and said: Fetch me a little water in a vessel, that I may drink. And as she was going to fetch it he called after her and said: Bring me, please, a morsel of bread in your hand. And she said: As the LORD your God lives, I have no loaf, only a handful of flour in the jar and a little oil in the jug. And here I am gathering two sticks, to go in and prepare it for myself and my son, that we may eat it, and die. (1 Kgs 17:10-12)

[Halo function: CAUSE. Her oath is sworn by your God, not hers, which is the corpus fixing her as a foreigner in her own mouth.]

And Elijah said to her: Do not fear. Go and do as you have said, but first make me a small cake from it and bring it out to me, and afterward make for yourself and for your son. For thus says the LORD, the God of Israel: the jar of flour shall not be spent and the jug of oil shall not fail, until the day the LORD sends rain upon the face of the earth. (1 Kgs 17:13-14)

And she went and did according to the word of Elijah. And she ate, she and he and her house, for days. The jar of flour was not spent and the jug of oil did not fail, according to the word of the LORD which he spoke by the hand of Elijah. (1 Kgs 17:15-16)

[Gap declaration: for days, which the Hebrew leaves indefinite. The corpus gives no count of months or seasons in the widow's house.]

Then the arrangement collapses from inside.

And after these things the son of the woman, the mistress of the house, fell sick, and his sickness was very severe, until no breath was left in him. And she said to Elijah: What have I to do with you, man of God? You have come to me to bring my guilt to remembrance and to kill my son. (1 Kgs 17:17-18)

[Match-class: TITLED. The first occurrence of man of God is an accusation, not an honorific.]

And he said to her: Give me your son. And he took him from her lap and carried him up to the upper room where he was staying, and laid him on his own bed. And he cried out to the LORD and said: LORD my God, have you also brought evil on this widow with whom I am staying, by killing her son? (1 Kgs 17:19-20)

[Attested interiority, first instance. The corpus does not report his thought. It reports him arraigning God aloud, in the same grammatical posture in which he later arraigns a king, and the protest is preserved without correction or rebuke.]

And he stretched himself over the child three times and cried out to the LORD and said: LORD my God, let the life of this child return within him. And the LORD heard the voice of Elijah, and the life of the child returned within him, and he lived. And Elijah took the child and brought him down from the upper room into the house and gave him to his mother. And Elijah said: See, your son lives. And the woman said to Elijah: Now, this I know, that you are a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in your mouth is truth. (1 Kgs 17:21-24)

[*Halo function: CONSEQUENCE. The section closes on her line, not his. The corpus gives the verdict on him to a foreign widow.*]

BOX | C STRUCTURAL COMMENT · UNCLEAN BREAD, THE LOCATED WORD, AND AN UNNAMED GUILT

The ravens are barred from the table by the law itself. The raven stands on the detestable list at Leviticus 11:15 and Deuteronomy 14:14. The sustenance is therefore not merely wild and outside royal reach; it is outside priestly reach as well. The prophet is fed twice daily, by divine command, by what the law excludes. The later resonance is not accidental either, since the corpus deliberately dresses his successor-figure in the same garment, hairy and leather-belted.

Where the word sits, tracked three times. The identification of this prophet with a divine Word does not hold in this chapter, and the reason is grammatical: the word of the LORD always comes *to* him, and he is the recipient and never the referent. What the chapter does instead is more interesting, and it is visible only when the three occurrences are read together. At 17:1 it is *ki-dvarī*, by my word, claimed as his own. At 17:16 it is *be-yad Ēliyyāhū*, by the hand of Elijah. At 17:24 the widow closes the chapter with *devar YHWH be-fikha emet*, the word of the LORD in your mouth is truth. By my word, by his hand, in his mouth. The chapter opens with him claiming the word and closes with a foreign woman locating it inside his body.

The guilt is raised and left unnamed, and the silence is doing work. The text gives *lehazkīr et-awōnī*, to bring my guilt to remembrance, and specifies nothing further. Reading it as the guilt of Eden, with eating and sexuality fused, imports something not present in Genesis 3, which has eating and nothing else; that fusion enters through much later interpretation and does not belong in the narration. The reading available inside the pericope is simpler and sharper. She swore *hay YHWH elohekha*, as the LORD *your* God lives, marking herself outside the covenant in her own mouth two verses earlier, and a Sidonian widow whose house a man of God has entered has an evident standing before that God which is not sexual. Note also that *yahid*, the only-son word of the binding of Ishaq AS, was available to this writer and is not used. The corpus raises a guilt and declines to name it, and what belongs in the record is the declining.

The vertical inversion. He carries the child up dead, *wayyaalēhū*, and brings him down alive, *wayyōridēhū*. That is the only vertical movement in the entire cycle apart from his own, and the signatures are opposite. The child goes up dead and comes down living. He goes up living and does not come down.

Man of God is an office, not a species. The phrase is used of Musa AS, of Samuel, of Shemaiah, of Elisha AS repeatedly, and of an anonymous prophet through a whole chapter of this same book. The word for a heavenly messenger is different and the cycle uses it separately and correctly throughout. What does survive, and it is better than an identification, is functional overlap without any confusion of terms: at Horeb a messenger touches him and feeds him bread that appears with no source, which is precisely what he did for the widow. The angel does to him what he did to her, and the corpus never once merges the vocabulary.

One notice from the other side of the treaty. Josephus, citing Menander of Ephesus on the Tyrian records, reports a drought in the reign of Ithobalos of Tyre lasting a year and ended by the king's supplication. This is a first-century author quoting a Hellenistic epitomiser of Tyrian annals, three removes from any archive, and it verifies nothing in Kings. What it is, and the distinction is worth keeping, is a notice of drought in the same reign window preserved on the other side of the same treaty, by a source with no interest in the Israelite prophet and no knowledge of him. It corroborates a climatic event and carries no further weight.

7. THE LIFE · IV. THE THIRD YEAR

And it came to pass after many days that the word of the LORD came to Elijah, in the third year, saying: Go, show yourself to Ahab, and I will send rain on the face of the earth. And Elijah went to show himself to Ahab. And the famine was severe in Samaria. (1 Kgs 18:1-2)

[Sequencing warrant: EXPLICIT, in the third year. This is the only interval the corpus counts in the whole drought sequence. The figure of three and a half years widely attached to it is not here and is not anywhere in Kings.]

And Ahab called Obadiah, who was over the household. Now Obadiah feared the LORD greatly. For when Jezebel was cutting off the prophets of the LORD, Obadiah took a hundred prophets and hid them, fifty men to a cave, and sustained them with bread and water. (1 Kgs 18:3-4)

[Halo function: CAUSE. The persecution and its counter-operation are introduced in a parenthesis, and the man running the counter-operation is the king's own household officer.]

And Ahab said to Obadiah: Go through the land, to all the springs of water and to all the wadis. Perhaps we shall find grass and keep horse and mule alive, and not lose the animals. (1 Kgs 18:5)

They divide the land between them and Obadiah walks into him on the road.

And Obadiah was on the way, and Elijah met him. And he recognised him and fell on his face and said: Is it you, my lord Elijah? And he said to him: It is I. Go, say to your lord, Elijah is here. (1 Kgs 18:7-8)

And he said: What have I sinned, that you are giving your servant into the hand of Ahab to kill me? As the LORD your God lives, there is no nation or kingdom where my lord has not sent to seek you, and when they said he is not here, he made the kingdom and the nation swear that they had not found you. And now you say, Go, say to your lord, Elijah is here. And it will happen, when I go from you, that the spirit of the LORD will carry you off to where I do not know, and I will come to tell Ahab and he will not find you, and he will kill me. And your servant has feared the LORD from my youth. (1 Kgs 18:9-12)

[Attested interiority, second instance, and it is not the prophet's. The corpus reports the fear of the man who financed the resistance, at length, in his own voice, and it reports the reason: the prophet has a documented habit of vanishing.]

And Elijah said: As the LORD of hosts lives, before whom I stand, today I will show myself to him. And Obadiah went to meet Ahab and told him, and Ahab went to meet Elijah. (1 Kgs 18:15-16)

And it came to pass, when Ahab saw Elijah, that Ahab said to him: Is it you, troubler of Israel? And he said: I have not troubled Israel, but you and your father's house, in that you have forsaken the commandments of the LORD and you have gone after the Baals. Now send and gather to me all Israel at Mount Carmel, and the four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and the four hundred prophets of the Asherah who eat at Jezebel's table. (1 Kgs 18:17-19)

[Halo function: CAUSE. The payroll is named in the same breath as the summons. The number and the table are the same fact.]

BOX | D STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE HUNDRED IN THE CAVES

The refutation arrives before the claim. Obadiah tells him directly that he hid a hundred prophets, fifty to a cave, and sustained them with bread and water. Eleven verses later, on the mountain, he says that he alone is left. The corpus therefore supplies the contradiction in advance, from a named eyewitness, in conversation with the man who will make the claim. This governs how the Carmel line and the doubled report at Horeb should be read, and both are treated where they stand.

The funder held the senior office of the kingdom. *Al ha-bayit*, over the house, is the chief household position, attested across the Iron Age Levant by seal impressions and inscriptions bearing the title. So the man financing and concealing the entire surviving prophetic guild was doing it from inside the royal establishment, at mortal risk, while continuing to run the king's affairs. The corpus also preserves his fear at length, and gives its reason: the prophet has a documented habit of vanishing, and the steward will be the one killed for it. That is the cost of association, recorded from the associate's side.

The prostration. Falling on the face and saying *adonī*, my lord, are both ordinary deference in this corpus, used constantly of kings and elders. What the passage carries is not a heavenly identification but a practical one: he is treated as a man who may not be where he was left.

8. THE LIFE · V. CARMEL

And Ahab sent to all the sons of Israel and gathered the prophets to Mount Carmel. And Elijah drew near to all the people and said: How long will you go limping between two forks? If the LORD is God, go after him, and if Baal, go after him. And the people did not answer him a word. (1 Kgs 18:20-21)

And Elijah said to the people: I alone am left a prophet of the LORD, and the prophets of Baal are four hundred and fifty men. Let them give us two bulls, and let them choose one bull for themselves and cut it up and set it on the wood, and put no fire. And I will prepare the other bull and set it on the wood, and put no fire. And you will call on the name of your god and I will call on the name of the LORD, and the God who answers by fire, he is God. And all the people answered and said: The word is good. (1 Kgs 18:22-24)

[*The criterion is announced once, before either attempt, and it is single. The people ratify the procedure before it runs.*]

And Elijah said to the prophets of Baal: Choose one bull for yourselves and prepare it first, for you are the many. And call on the name of your god, and put no fire. (1 Kgs 18:25)

[*The order of attempt is conceded, and the ground of the concession is stated: numbers.*]

And they took the bull that was given them and prepared it, and called on the name of Baal from morning until noon, saying: Baal, answer us. But there was no voice and none answering. And they limped about the altar that was made. (1 Kgs 18:26)

And it came to pass at noon that Elijah mocked them and said: Call with a great voice, for he is a god. Perhaps he is musing, or has stepped aside, or is on a journey. Perhaps he is asleep and must be awakened. And they called with a great voice and cut themselves, as was their custom, with swords and lances until blood poured over them. (1 Kgs 18:27-28)

And it came to pass, when midday had passed, that they raved until the time of the evening offering. And there was no voice, and none answering, and no attention. (1 Kgs 18:29)

And Elijah said to all the people: Come near to me. And all the people came near to him. And he repaired the ruined altar of the LORD. And Elijah took twelve stones, according to the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob, to whom the word of the LORD had come, saying, Israel shall be your name. And he built the stones into an altar in the name of the LORD, and made a channel around the altar large enough for two measures of seed. (1 Kgs 18:30-32)

And he arranged the wood and cut up the bull and set it on the wood. And he said: Fill four jars with water and pour it on the burnt offering and on the wood. And he said: Do it a second time. And they did it a second time. And he said: Do it a third time. And they did it a third time. And the water ran around the altar, and he also filled the channel with water. (1 Kgs 18:33-35)

And it came to pass at the time of the evening offering that Elijah the prophet drew near and said: LORD, God of Abraham, Isaac and Israel, let it be known today that you are God in Israel, and that I am your servant, and that by your word I have done all these things. Answer me, LORD, answer me, and let this people know that you, LORD, are God, and that you have turned their heart back. (1 Kgs 18:36-37)

[Attested interiority, third instance. In the whole of the Carmel sequence the only glimpse the corpus gives of his own standing is the middle clause, that I am your servant and that by your word I have done all these things, spoken aloud in petition. There is no reported thought anywhere on the mountain.]

And the fire of the LORD fell and consumed the burnt offering and the wood and the stones and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the channel. And all the people saw and fell on their faces and said: The LORD, he is God. The LORD, he is God. (1 Kgs 18:38-39)

And Elijah said to them: Seize the prophets of Baal, let not a man of them escape. And they seized them, and Elijah brought them down to the wadi Kishon and slaughtered them there. (1 Kgs 18:40)

[Printed as the corpus prints it, in sequence, without softening and without comment. The connective register makes no judgment here; the instrument reads conduct and does not adjudicate it.]

BOX | E STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE DESIGN AT CARMEL

I alone am left is not a claim about his nature. Obadiah's hundred refute it eleven verses earlier, and Horeb answers the doubled report with seven thousand. What the line carries is the arithmetic of the moment: one against four hundred and fifty is the asymmetry that justifies conceding first attempt, and the concession is the design's load-bearing feature.

The two bulls are symmetric on purpose. Identical animals, their choice of which, identical wood, no fire from either side, one announced criterion. A distinction carried into the test in advance would make the test theatre; the distinction is produced by the test. The people's ratification, *tōv ha-dāvār*, the word is good, is the consent that makes this an adjudication rather than a spectacle.

The mockery argues about a category, not a capacity. Four predicates: musing, turned aside, on a journey, and asleep and needing to be woken. The second carries a well-attested reading as a bodily euphemism, which puts the taunt lower than most translations convey. The argument is that a god who can be absent, travelling, or asleep is a god of a certain kind. The Quranic Throne Verse negates the sleep pair explicitly, that neither drowsiness nor sleep overtakes Him, and adds that sustaining the heavens and the earth does not weary Him. Two scriptures, one structural target, and the comparison is worth stating and worth not overstating.

The twelve stones name their own referent in the same verse, according to the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob, so calendrical and astral readings are not needed and are not supported. The internal referent does harder work in any case. He builds a twelve-stone altar in a kingdom of ten tribes, which is masonry asserting that the split is not real, and his invocation matches the stones: Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, the renaming clause that same verse has just quoted. A political claim in stone and in a vocative.

The water is a control condition, installed before the test. Four jars, three times, poured over offering, wood, and altar until the trench is full. It eliminates the obvious confound in advance rather than answering it afterward, and the corpus does not repeat this design anywhere else. The arithmetic also yields twelve, matching the stones; the text draws no line between the two counts, and the coincidence is recorded rather than pressed.

The petition, and the contrast in expenditure. Three clauses, and the middle one stakes his own neck: that You are God in Israel, that I am Your servant, and that by Your word I have done all these things. He staked his standing in his first sentence with *except by my word*, and this is where that account is settled. Against it stands the method of the four hundred and fifty: from morning to evening, crying, leaping, and blood. He speaks roughly thirty words at the hour of the evening offering. Maximal expenditure against minimal, staged deliberately.

The site is a border sanctuary and the venue is part of the claim. Carmel is the ridge running to the sea at the boundary between Israelite territory and the Phoenician coastal zone. Tacitus records Vespasian sacrificing at an altar on Carmel with no temple and no image, which indicates an open-air cult there of considerable antiquity. A contest staged on that ridge is a jurisdiction claim over a frontier holy place, which is the geographical form of the same dispute the drought opened.

9. THE LIFE · VI. THE RAIN, AND THE RUN

And Elijah said to Ahab: Go up, eat and drink, for there is the sound of the roar of rain. And Ahab went up to eat and drink. And Elijah went up to the top of Carmel, and he bowed to the earth and put his face between his knees. (1 Kgs 18:41-42)

[Attested interiority, fourth instance, and the corpus gives it as posture rather than as thought. The face between the knees is the only interior state in the chapter and it is reported from outside.]

And he said to his servant: Go up now, look toward the sea. And he went up and looked and said: There is nothing. And he said: Go back, seven times. And it came to pass at the seventh time that he said: See, a small cloud like a man's palm rising from the sea. And he said: Go up, say to Ahab, Harness and go down, that the rain not stop you. (1 Kgs 18:43-44)

And it came to pass in the meantime that the heavens grew black with clouds and wind, and there was a great rain. And Ahab rode and went to Jezreel. And the hand of the LORD was on Elijah, and he girded his loins and ran before Ahab until you come to Jezreel. (1 Kgs 18:45-46)

[Halo function: CONSEQUENCE. The chapter closes with the prophet running as outrunner before the king's chariot, which is the posture of a royal servant, and it is the last moment in the corpus at which he and Ahab are on the same side of anything.]

BOX | F STRUCTURAL COMMENT · A POSTURE WITH NO OTHER INSTANCE

The Hebrew is *wayyighar aršāh wayyāsem pānāv bēn birkāv*, he crouched to the earth and set his face between his knees. This is not the corpus's prostration vocabulary, and the distinction is deliberate rather than incidental, since the corpus uses that vocabulary freely in the immediate context: the people fall on their faces at the fire, and Obadiah falls on his at the meeting. Of Ilyas AS neither term is ever used. The crouched, knees-drawn posture is unique in the Hebrew Bible, and what he holds it through is a servant going up and returning seven times while water gathers over the sea.

10. THE LIFE · VII. THE BROOM TREE, AND THE MOUNTAIN

And Ahab told Jezebel all that Elijah had done, and all how he had killed all the prophets with the sword. And Jezebel sent a messenger to Elijah, saying: So may the gods do to me and more, if by this time tomorrow I do not make your life like the life of one of them. (1 Kgs 19:1-2)

[Sequencing warrant: EXPLICIT, by this time tomorrow. The threat follows the killing at the Kishon and is framed by the corpus as a response to it, in that order.]

And he saw, and he arose and went for his life, and came to Beersheba which belongs to Judah, and left his servant there. And he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness, and came and sat under a single broom bush. And he asked for his life to die, and said: Enough now, LORD. Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers. (1 Kgs 19:3-4)

[Attested interiority, fifth instance and the strongest in the corpus. The Hebrew *wayyish'al et-nafsho lamut* places the request on his own nefesh and is the nearest thing to reported inner motion anywhere in the cycle. The self-assessment that follows is spoken and is preserved without mitigation.]

And he lay down and slept under a single broom bush. And behold, a messenger touched him and said to him: Arise, eat. And he looked, and at his head was a cake baked on hot stones and a jug of water. And he ate and drank and lay down again. And the messenger of the LORD returned a second time and touched him

and said: Arise, eat, for the journey is too much for you. And he arose and ate and drank, and went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb, the mountain of God. (1 Kgs 19:5-8)

[The corpus gives food twice and no speech before it. Nothing is asked of him until after the second meal.]

And he came there to the cave and lodged there. And behold, the word of the LORD came to him and said to him: What are you doing here, Elijah? And he said: I have been very zealous for the LORD, God of hosts, for the sons of Israel have forsaken your covenant, thrown down your altars, and killed your prophets with the sword. And I alone am left, and they seek my life to take it. (1 Kgs 19:9-10)

And he said: Go out and stand on the mountain before the LORD. And behold, the LORD passing by, and a great and strong wind tearing mountains and shattering rocks before the LORD. The LORD was not in the wind. And after the wind an earthquake. The LORD was not in the earthquake. And after the earthquake a fire. The LORD was not in the fire. And after the fire, a voice of thin silence. (1 Kgs 19:11-12)

[The closing phrase, qol demamah daqqah, pairs voice with silence and then attenuates it, and every rendering sacrifices one of the three terms. The three negated elements are the storm-god's entire signature vocabulary.]

And it came to pass, when Elijah heard, that he wrapped his face in his mantle and went out and stood at the entrance of the cave. And behold, a voice came to him and said: What are you doing here, Elijah? And he said: I have been very zealous for the LORD, God of hosts, for the sons of Israel have forsaken your covenant, thrown down your altars, and killed your prophets with the sword. And I alone am left, and they seek my life to take it. (1 Kgs 19:13-14)

[The question is asked twice and the answer is given twice, identical to the word. The corpus makes no adjustment to his account after the theophany, which is a structural refusal to let the experience change his testimony.]

And the LORD said to him: Go, return on your way to the wilderness of Damascus. And when you arrive, you shall anoint Hazael as king over Aram. And Jehu son of Nimshi you shall anoint as king over Israel. And Elisha son of Shaphat of Abel-meholah you shall anoint as prophet in your place. And it shall be, whoever escapes the sword of Hazael, Jehu shall kill, and whoever escapes the sword of Jehu, Elisha shall kill. And I have left in Israel seven thousand, all the knees that have not bowed to Baal and every mouth that has not kissed him. (1 Kgs 19:15-18)

[The answer to his doubled self-report is a correction of its count. He said he alone was left; the reply gives a figure. The corpus preserves the correction of its own protagonist.]

BOX | G STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE BROOM TREE, THE THIN SILENCE, AND THE DEVOLVED METHOD

The despair, and its closer parallel. He does not say that he has been abandoned. He says take my life, *for I am no better than my fathers*, which is a verdict on himself, and what he receives is food, sleep, and a corrected headcount rather than vindication. The near-verbatim match lies inside the same corpus: Yunus AS at Jonah 4:3, take my life from me, for my death is better than my life, likewise spoken after the mission had succeeded rather than after it failed. Two prophets, both asking to die at the moment of vindication.

Forty days runs upstream. Exodus 34:28 and Deuteronomy 9:9 give the same count, and he is walking to the same mountain under the same name. Musa AS stands upstream and this prophet downstream of him, which is also why later tradition places these two figures together on a mountain and no others.

The cascade, and what it actually negates. Three manifestations, three negation formulas of identical construction, *lo va-ruah*, *lo va-raash*, *lo va-esh*, and then a fourth term that is not negated. That is an apophatic sequence terminating in a remainder, and the count of three is in the text rather than imposed on it.

The precision that matters, and it corrects a looser formulation, is that the passage does not empty the storm vocabulary. The wind genuinely tears mountains and shatters rocks, the earthquake genuinely occurs, the fire genuinely burns. They are present and denied as the locus, not absent. The negation is not that there was no wind but that there was a great wind and He was not in it. A cascade of absences would be trivial. A cascade of actual events, each denied as the site, is a far harder thing to construct, and it is what the text constructs.

And the three are not abstract registers. They are the inventory of Sinai. Exodus 19:16-18 gives thunder, thick cloud, fire, smoke, and the whole mountain trembling. This passage presents the Sinai manifestation-set, at Sinai, under its other name, to a prophet whom the narrative has already typed as a second Musa AS through the forty days, the cave, the covered face, and the commission received on the mountain. What is denied is therefore not a category of phenomenon. It is the precedent. The man sent to repeat Sinai is shown Sinai and told that the locus has moved.

The method that follows matches the theophany in form. Immediately after a manifestation that declines the spectacular, the instruction is three appointments and no further fire: Hazael abroad, Jehu inside, Elisha AS in the prophetic line, with the chain stated as sword passing to sword passing to sword. He performs none of the killings, and he performs only one of the three anointings, since Hazael and Jehu are anointed by Elisha AS and by a servant of Elisha AS, a further generation down. Three commissions, one executed personally and two devolved twice. Jezreel is not bypassed by this: it is exactly where the purge lands and where the queen dies, fulfilling the vineyard oracle to the address, and the man who spoke that word is two generations gone by then.

They never share a scene. He confronts Ahab four times. She reaches him once, by messenger, and he reaches her once, by an oracle delivered to her husband. They are never in the same place in the entire cycle. On the plain order of the text her threat follows the killing at the Kishon rather than preceding it, which makes it retaliation for the execution of several hundred of her clergy. The oracle against her goes to the man holding the seal, which is where the legal liability sits.

II. THE LIFE · VIII. THE MANTLE

And he went from there and found Elisha son of Shaphat, and he was ploughing, twelve pair before him, and he with the twelfth. And Elijah crossed to him and threw his mantle over him. And he left the oxen and ran

after Elijah and said: Let me kiss my father and my mother, and then I will follow you. And he said to him: Go, return, for what have I done to you? (1 Kgs 19:19-20)

And he returned from following him, and took the pair of oxen and slaughtered them, and with the gear of the oxen he boiled their flesh and gave it to the people, and they ate. And he arose and went after Elijah and served him. (1 Kgs 19:21)

[Halo function: *CONSEQUENCE*. The successor destroys his own means of return in front of witnesses. Twelve pair working one field is an estate, not a smallholding.]

[Gap declaration: between this scene and the next unit the corpus supplies nothing. No duration, no location, no activity. Everything usually assumed about the years of teaching between master and successor is assumption.]

BOX | H STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE PRICE OF ENTRY

Twelve pair of oxen working one field is an estate with a labour force, not a smallholding. He is taken from prosperity rather than from want.

What he then does the narrative reports without comment, and it is the whole of its meaning. He slaughters the pair, burns the ploughing gear to cook the meat, feeds the people, and follows. The gear is the means of return; burning it makes the decision irreversible, and doing it in front of the people makes it witnessed. The corpus preserves the price of entry into an office that carries no salary, paid publicly and paid at once.

12. THE LIFE · IX. THE VINEYARD

The corpus turns aside from him for a full chapter and gives the crime first, in legal detail, before he appears in it.

And it came to pass after these things that Naboth the Jezreelite had a vineyard in Jezreel beside the palace of Ahab king of Samaria. And Ahab spoke to Naboth saying: Give me your vineyard, that it may be a vegetable garden for me, for it is near beside my house, and I will give you in its place a vineyard better than it. Or if it is good in your eyes, I will give you its worth in silver. And Naboth said to Ahab: Far be it from me, by the LORD, that I should give the inheritance of my fathers to you. (1 Kgs 21:1-3)

[Halo function: *CAUSE*. The king's opening move is a lawful purchase or exchange at the owner's choice. The refusal is on the ground of *naḥalah*, patrimony, and the corpus preserves both the legality of the offer and the legality of the refusal.]

And Ahab came to his house sullen and angry over the word Naboth the Jezreelite had spoken to him, and he lay down on his bed and turned away his face and would not eat bread. (1 Kgs 21:4)

[Attested interiority, and it belongs to the king. The corpus reports Ahab's interior state at greater length here than it reports the prophet's anywhere in the cycle.]

And Jezebel his wife came to him and said: Why is your spirit sullen, that you eat no bread? ... And Jezebel his wife said to him: Do you now govern Israel? Arise, eat bread, and let your heart be good. I will give you the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite. (1 Kgs 21:5-7)

And she wrote letters in Ahab's name and sealed them with his seal, and sent the letters to the elders and to the nobles who were in his city, dwelling with Naboth. And she wrote in the letters saying: Proclaim a fast and seat Naboth at the head of the people. And seat two men, sons of worthlessness, opposite him, and let them testify against him saying, You have blessed God and king. And take him out and stone him, that he may die. (1 Kgs 21:8-10)

And the men of his city, the elders and the nobles who dwelt in his city, did as Jezebel had sent to them, as it was written in the letters she had sent to them. (1 Kgs 21:11)

[*The instrument is preserved whole: royal seal, written instruction, local judiciary, correct two-witness form, capital charge, execution outside the city, and compliance reported back. The seizure runs through the courts, not around them.*]

And it came to pass, when Jezebel heard that Naboth had been stoned and was dead, that Jezebel said to Ahab: Arise, take possession of the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite, which he refused to give you for silver, for Naboth is not alive but dead. And it came to pass, when Ahab heard that Naboth was dead, that Ahab arose to go down to the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite, to take possession of it. (1 Kgs 21:15-16)

And the word of the LORD came to Elijah the Tishbite: Arise, go down to meet Ahab king of Israel who is in Samaria. Behold, he is in the vineyard of Naboth, where he has gone down to take possession of it. And you shall speak to him saying: Thus says the LORD, Have you murdered and also taken possession? And you shall speak to him saying: Thus says the LORD, In the place where the dogs licked the blood of Naboth, the dogs shall lick your blood, yours also. (1 Kgs 21:17-19)

[*Sequencing warrant: EXPLICIT. The commission places him at the vineyard while the king is still standing in it.*]

And Ahab said to Elijah: Have you found me, my enemy? And he said: I have found you, because you have sold yourself to do what is evil in the eyes of the LORD. (1 Kgs 21:20)

And also concerning Jezebel the LORD spoke, saying: The dogs shall eat Jezebel by the rampart of Jezreel. (1 Kgs 21:23)

And it came to pass, when Ahab heard these words, that he tore his clothes and put sackcloth on his flesh and fasted, and lay in sackcloth and walked about softly. And the word of the LORD came to Elijah the Tishbite saying: Have you seen how Ahab has humbled himself before me? Because he has humbled himself before me, I will not bring the evil in his days. In his son's days I will bring the evil on his house. (1 Kgs 21:27-29)

[*Halo function: CONSEQUENCE. The corpus preserves the king's repentance and the deferral of the sentence, which the transmitting school had no obligation to include and which complicates its own verdict on him.*]

BOX | I STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE PATRIMONY, AND THE MAN WITH NONE

The chapter's legal term is *naḥalāh*, the patrimonial allotment held inalienable in principle at Leviticus 25:23, which is the same verse that supplies *tōshāb*, the resident alien. If the gentilic at the opening carries that wordplay, then the man introduced as a resident alien among resident aliens is the man who arraigns a king for seizing a patrimony, and both terms come from one verse of the law. The text draws no line between them; the coincidence of vocabulary is recorded and left there.

The downstream is the longest in the cycle. This scene supplies the founding case for the prophetic critique of expropriation, and its later exponents work visibly from it. Amos on selling the needy for a pair of sandals and trampling the head of the poor. Isaiah AS on those who join house to house and field to field until there is no room. Micah on those who covet fields and seize them, houses and take them away, oppressing a man and his house, a man and his patrimony, which reuses Naboth's own term. A tradition of economic critique beginning with a general denunciation would be a weaker instrument, and the specificity here is what made it citable for three centuries.

One datum complicates the chapter's reputation. The corpus reports the king's interior state at greater length than it reports the prophet's anywhere in the cycle: sullen, angry, turned to the wall, refusing bread. It also preserves his lawful opening offer, his acceptance of the refusal, his later repentance in sackcloth, and the deferral of sentence that followed it. A tradition committed to his condemnation preserved all four.

13. THE LIFE · X. THE MESSENGERS AND THE FIRE

Ahab is dead. The corpus does not place Ilyas AS at the death and gives it to a random arrow and a washed chariot (1 Kgs 22:34-38). His next appearance is under the son.

And Ahaziah fell through the lattice in his upper room in Samaria and was injured. And he sent messengers and said to them: Go, inquire of Baal-zebub the god of Ekron whether I shall recover from this injury. And a messenger of the LORD spoke to Elijah the Tishbite: Arise, go up to meet the messengers of the king of Samaria and say to them: Is it because there is no God in Israel that you are going to inquire of Baal-zebub the god of Ekron? Therefore thus says the LORD: the bed you have gone up on, you shall not come down from it, for you shall surely die. And Elijah went. (2 Kgs 1:2-4)

[Sequencing warrant: IMPLIED by reign. The dependency is the succession, and the corpus supplies no interval.]

And the messengers returned to him, and he said to them: Why have you returned? ... And he said to them: What was the manner of the man who came up to meet you and spoke these words to you? And they said to him: A man, an owner of hair, and a belt of leather bound at his waist. And he said: It is Elijah the Tishbite. (2 Kgs 1:5-8)

[Match-class: TITLED, and the only physical description of him in the entire corpus. He is identified by a garment and a body, at second hand, by a king who has never seen him.]

And the king sent to him a captain of fifty with his fifty. And he went up to him, and behold, he was sitting on the top of the hill. And he spoke to him: Man of God, the king has said, Come down. And Elijah answered and spoke to the captain of fifty: And if I am a man of God, let fire come down from the heavens

and consume you and your fifty. And fire came down from the heavens and consumed him and his fifty. (2 Kgs 1:9-10)

And he sent to him again another captain of fifty with his fifty... and fire of God came down from the heavens and consumed him and his fifty. (2 Kgs 1:11-12)

And he sent again a third captain of fifty with his fifty. And the third captain of fifty went up and came and knelt on his knees before Elijah, and pleaded with him and spoke to him: Man of God, let my life and the life of these fifty your servants be precious in your eyes. Behold, fire came down from the heavens and consumed the two former captains of fifty and their fifties. And now, let my life be precious in your eyes. And a messenger of the LORD spoke to Elijah: Go down with him, do not fear him. And he arose and went down with him to the king. (2 Kgs 1:13-15)

[The third man's speech is the longest sustained address to him by a stranger in the corpus, and it is preserved in full including the count of the dead.]

And he spoke to him: Thus says the LORD, Because you sent messengers to inquire of Baal-zebub the god of Ekron, is it because there is no God in Israel to inquire of his word? Therefore the bed you have gone up on, you shall not come down from it, for you shall surely die. And he died according to the word of the LORD which Elijah had spoken. (2 Kgs 1:16-17)

[Gap declaration: between this and the departure the corpus supplies nothing whatsoever.]

14. THE LIFE · XI. THE DEPARTURE

The corpus opens the chapter by telling the reader the ending before the scene begins, which is how it signals that the movement of the chapter is not suspense but transfer.

And it came to pass, when the LORD was about to take Elijah up in a whirlwind to the heavens, that Elijah went with Elisha from Gilgal. (2 Kgs 2:1)

And Elijah said to Elisha: Stay here, please, for the LORD has sent me as far as Bethel. And Elisha said: As the LORD lives and as your soul lives, I will not leave you. And they went down to Bethel. And the sons of the prophets who were at Bethel came out to Elisha and said to him: Do you know that today the LORD is taking your master from over your head? And he said: I also know. Be silent. (2 Kgs 2:2-3)

[The exchange repeats verbatim at Jericho and again at the Jordan, three times, each with the same refusal and the same instruction to be silent. The repetition is the corpus's device and is not compressed here.]

And fifty men of the sons of the prophets went and stood opposite at a distance, and the two of them stood at the Jordan. And Elijah took his mantle and rolled it up and struck the waters, and they divided here and there, and the two of them crossed on dry ground. (2 Kgs 2:7-8)

And it came to pass, as they crossed, that Elijah said to Elisha: Ask what I shall do for you, before I am taken from you. And Elisha said: Let there be, please, a double portion of your spirit upon me. And he said: You have asked a hard thing. If you see me taken from you it shall be so for you, and if not, it shall not be. (2 Kgs 2:9-10)

[*The request is filed in inheritance vocabulary. Pi shnayim, the double portion, is the firstborn's share of an estate. He is claiming a patrimony from a man who holds none.*]

And it came to pass, as they went on walking and speaking, that behold, a chariot of fire and horses of fire, and they separated the two of them. And Elijah went up in the whirlwind to the heavens. And Elisha was seeing, and he was crying out: My father, my father, the chariot of Israel and its horsemen. And he did not see him again. (2 Kgs 2:11-12)

[*Match-class: TITLED. The last name given him in his own presence is my father, and it is given by a man who is not his son.*]

And he took hold of his clothes and tore them in two pieces. And he picked up the mantle of Elijah that had fallen from him, and returned and stood on the bank of the Jordan. (2 Kgs 2:12-13)

Then the corpus does something a hagiography would not.

And the sons of the prophets who were at Jericho, opposite, saw him and said: The spirit of Elijah rests on Elisha. And they came to meet him and bowed to the ground before him. And they said to him: Behold now, there are with your servants fifty men, sons of valour. Let them go, please, and seek your master. Perhaps the spirit of the LORD has lifted him and cast him on one of the mountains or in one of the valleys. And he said: Do not send. And they urged him until he was ashamed, and he said: Send. And they sent fifty men, and they sought three days and did not find him. And they returned to him while he was staying at Jericho, and he said to them: Did I not say to you, Do not go? (2 Kgs 2:15-18)

[*The eyewitness disciples conduct a three-day search for a body, over the successor's objection, and fail. The corpus preserves their doubt and his shame at being overruled, and the passage is entirely dispensable to the narrative, which closes cleanly two verses earlier.*]

There is no burial notice. Kings closes every reign and most careers with a place of burial and a successor. Here there is a mantle on a riverbank and a search that fails.

BOX | J STRUCTURAL COMMENT · BETHEL, THE RIVER, AND THE INHERITANCE THAT NEEDS A WITNESS

Bethel is the right site and the reason is stronger than the name. It is not merely house of God. It is Jeroboam's rival sanctuary with a golden calf, the northern kingdom's alternative to Jerusalem, and the standing indictment repeated over every northern reign. The guild of prophets is therefore stationed inside the compromised sanctuary. And the departure route, Gilgal, Bethel, Jericho, Jordan, retraces the conquest entry in reverse: he leaves the land the way Israel came into it, backwards, through the rival shrine.

One correction worth making because the names invite it. Bethel is not Bethlehem. *Bêt- Ēl*, house of God, and *Bêt-Leḥem*, house of bread, differ in the second element and are distinct sites some fifteen miles apart. The later typology built on this prophet runs through the Jordan and the garment, and the Jordan is exactly where this passage ends.

The water is a chain with a middle link. Mantle rolled, waters divided this way and that, crossing on *ḥārāvāh*, dry ground, which is the word used at the sea. Then Elisha AS strikes with the same mantle, asks where is the God of Elijah, and the waters part again, at the same river and near the same place as the crossing under Joshua. He leaves by the Jordan as Israel entered by the Jordan and departed Egypt by the sea, and the mantle is the instrument in both halves, which is why the succession runs through a garment rather than through a document.

The double portion is an inheritance claim in legal vocabulary. *Pī shnayim* is the firstborn's share at Deuteronomy 21:17, two thirds against one third, not twice the father's. He is asking to be treated as heir to an estate whose only asset is an office.

And the inheritance is made conditional on witnessing. If you see me taken from you, it shall be so for you, and if not, it shall not be. Witnessing is precisely what the departing party cannot perform for himself, since no one can testify to his own departure. The transfer therefore requires an external observer, and the observer's seeing is the mechanism of the transfer rather than a report about it. The corpus then supplies the negative result in the same chapter: fifty men search three days for a body, over the heir's objection, and find nothing. What follows is not a return upon itself but a chain: Elisha AS sees, tears his clothes, takes up the mantle, and the guild watching from a distance reads the result off him and acclaims it.

Three passages survive against the interest of those who preserved them. This is the sharpest kind of evidence a transmitted corpus can produce, because a transmitting class controls selection absolutely and unsupported material dies quietly by default.

The three-day search is the clearest case. The guild's authority in this very passage rests on the ascension and on the legitimacy of the succession, and the episode records that the eyewitness disciples did not find the ascension self-evident, mounted a search on the assumption of a body, and had to be told twice. It could have been omitted with no damage, since the narrative closes cleanly two verses earlier, and it supplies no advantage to anyone.

The collapse at Horeb is the second: the central figure shown broken, asking to die, declaring himself no better than his fathers, and factually wrong about the state of the resistance, with the correction supplied by a headcount.

The third case fails, and saying so matters. It is tempting to read the vineyard chapter the same way, since it indicts the elders and nobles who complied, that is, the judicial class ancestral to the transmitters. But those elders are northern, and the school that compiled this history was southern with a programme of indicting the north, so preserving their complicity served the compilers rather than costing them. The case does not hold and the chapter is read at ordinary weight.

The missing book is a documented differential, not an absence. Some sixty-three inscribed sherds from the Samarian acropolis record deliveries of oil and wine with regnal years, place names, and personal names, which puts administrative literacy inside the palace he confronted. Within roughly a century of his death, in his own kingdom, Amos and Hosea both leave collections under their own names, the two earliest such collections in the corpus. The format existed, the capacity existed, and the milieu adopted it within four generations. The greatest figure of that milieu leaves nothing. Two readings account for it and neither excludes the other: his medium was act rather than oracle, and confrontation does not accumulate into a scroll the way an oracle series does; and his transmission was built to run through a person rather than a text, which the corpus states directly, since the succession is a garment and an inheritance claim rather than an archive.

Why the missing grave is load-bearing. In this world a tomb is real estate and frequently a revenue centre. Cults anchor to sites, sites generate custodians, custodians generate income, and income generates a family with an interest in controlling the memory. The patriarchal burial cave is introduced with a full conveyance record, weighed silver and named witnesses, because a grave is property. Absent a body there is nothing to build on, nothing to charge admission to, and no lineage to inherit the custody. What cannot be territorialised travels. The parallel is not accidental either: Deuteronomy states that no one knows the burial place of Musa AS to this day, and the same tradition produced both notices.

15. THE WORD AFTER HIM

Three times after the departure the corpus audits his word against events and names him doing it. These are not biography and they are printed as their own class.

And they returned and told him. And he said: It is the word of the LORD which he spoke by the hand of his servant Elijah the Tishbite, saying: In the portion of Jezreel the dogs shall eat the flesh of Jezebel. (2 Kgs 9:36)

Know then that nothing of the word of the LORD shall fall to the earth, which the LORD spoke concerning the house of Ahab. And the LORD has done what he spoke by the hand of his servant Elijah. (2 Kgs 10:10)

And he struck down all who remained to Ahab in Samaria, until he had destroyed him, according to the word of the LORD which he spoke to Elijah. (2 Kgs 10:17)

[*Halo function: CONSEQUENCE. The speaker in the first two is Jehu, whose anointing was the third commission at Horeb. The corpus closes the loop by having the man Ilyas AS was told to anoint quote him by name while executing the sentence.*]

BOX | K STRUCTURAL COMMENT · WHAT FAILS TO HAPPEN WITHOUT HIM

The fulfilment notices are the corpus auditing its own word, so this is the place to ask what the word actually carried.

Much of it is substitutable, and the honest answer is the useful one. The destruction of the Tyrian Baal cult in Israel was carried out by an army coup rather than by a prophet, and that coup is dated from outside the Hebrew corpus by the Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III, which names Jehu paying tribute and fixes the event to 841 BCE. The fall of the dynasty is over-determined by any reasonable accounting: sustained Aramean pressure from Damascus, Assyrian expansion, the Moabite revolt recorded on Mesha's own stele, and an officer corps behind a usurper. Remove this prophet entirely and the house still falls on approximately that schedule, and the cult goes with it. Nor was he the only carrier of exclusive Yahwism, since the Rechabites appear two centuries later as an organised abstentionist lineage claiming a founder from this period, and the later reform is driven by a scroll and a king rather than by a prophet.

What is not substitutable is formal rather than eventual. The founding case for prophetic critique of expropriation, which three later prophets work from. The office itself, unfunded and unappointed, which its clearest later occupant describes from inside in the vocabulary of salary and guild. The relocation of divine presence away from spectacular manifestation, which later contemplative traditions in three religions return to. And the standing expectation created by a departure without a grave, treated at the close.

Which means the record is seating a shape rather than a set of deeds, and the shape is a configuration of absences: no book, no patron, no grave. A prophet who leaves a collection is bounded by his own text and can be argued with on the page. A prophet with a patron is answerable to the payer and reads as such. A prophet with a tomb becomes a site, and a site becomes a custody, and a custody becomes a lineage with an interest in what he meant. This transmission escaped all three, which is why a ninth-century confrontation is still supplying a legal device to one tradition, an announcement grammar to a second, and a named antagonist to a third.

16. PARALLEL BRANCH · THE QURANIC ACCOUNT

Run as a parallel branch. Not merged with the Hebrew arc, not inserted into its sequence, and not used to fill any gap declared above.

And Zakariyya AS and Yahya AS and 'Īsā AS and Ilyas AS: all were of the righteous. (Q 6:85)

[*Halo function: SETTING. A roster of the guided, in which he is one name among many and carries no episode.*]

And indeed, Ilyas AS was among the messengers, when he said to his people: Will you not be mindful? Do you call upon Baʿl and forsake the best of creators, Allah ﷻ, your Lord and the Lord of your forefathers? But they denied him, so indeed they will be brought forth, except the chosen servants of Allah ﷻ. And We left for him among the later generations: Peace upon Ilyasin. Indeed, thus do We reward the doers of good. Indeed, he was of Our believing servants. (Q 37:123-132)

[*Halo function: SERIES-FRAME. The closing quatrain here is structurally identical to the quatrains closing Nuh AS at 37:78-81, Ibrahim AS at 37:108-111, and Musa AS with Harun AS at 37:119-122. The brevity is a property of the series.*]

[Philological note: the form Ilyāsīn at 37:130 carries a documented reading variant, Āl Yāsīn, the family of Yasin. Carried as a reading-variant with the premise named, and not resolved here.]

What the branch preserves. The name of the rival god. *Baʿl* appears in this sense once in the whole Quran, in this passage, attached to this prophet. The Hebrew arc runs to roughly one hundred and forty-six verses and the Quranic branch to eleven, and what the eleven carry across is not a moral, not a miracle, and not a chronology, but the antagonist's proper name.

What the branch does not contain. No drought, no Cherith, no widow, no Obadiah, no Carmel, no ordeal, no rain, no broom tree, no Horeb, no mantle, no vineyard, no chariot, no departure, and no successor. The two accounts are not harmonised here and the difference in scale is printed as the finding.

BOX | L STRUCTURAL COMMENT · WHAT THE SHORTER ACCOUNT CARRIES

The Quranic passage closes on a clause that later reading has treated as more than an epithet. Across the same sura a formula recurs over successive messengers, and at its end a general judgment is stated with an exception carved out of it for the servants of Allah ﷻ who have been made sincere, *al-mukhlashūn*, the chosen and purified. Ilyas AS is named within that set, alongside Nuh AS, Ibrahim AS, Musa AS, Harun AS, and Lut AS. On that reading the exception clause functions as a severing operator rather than as praise, marking a group set apart from the general accounting.

What this adds to the shorter account is placement rather than content. The eleven verses do not fail to deliver a life. They deliver a position within a sequence, and position is what this corpus gives this figure, which is a different economy from chronicle rather than a smaller quantity of it. The theological weight of that placement is not adjudicated here and belongs to the reader's tradition.

Alongside it stands the single most specific thing the shorter account preserves. *Baʿl* occurs in this sense once in the entire Quran, here, attached to this prophet. A transmission that crossed roughly fifteen centuries, three language families, and at least two intermediate corpora carried forward neither a moral nor a miracle nor a chronology, but the antagonist's proper name.

17. UNPLACED · THE LETTER

Held out of the sequence, printed whole.

And a writing came to him from Elijah the prophet, saying: Thus says the LORD, God of David your father, Because you have not walked in the ways of Jehoshaphat your father nor in the ways of Asa king of Judah, but have walked in the way of the kings of Israel, and have made Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem go whoring like the whoring of the house of Ahab, and also have killed your brothers, the house of your father, better than you: behold, the LORD is striking a great blow among your people, your children, your wives and all your goods. And you shall have great sickness, a disease of your bowels, until your bowels come out by reason of the sickness, days upon days. (2 Chr 21:12-15)

[Why it is unplaced. The recipient is Jehoram of Judah, who reigns after the point at which Kings places the departure. Three readings are live and nothing in either corpus decides between them: the writing predates the departure and was delivered later, Kings places the departure non-chronologically, or the Chronicler has constructed the letter. Note also the form. It is the only written communication attributed to him anywhere, in a life otherwise conducted entirely by speech and act.]

18. FORWARD · THE SENDING

Outside the life, after it, and printed as its own class.

Behold, I am sending to you Elijah the prophet, before the coming of the day of the LORD, the great and the fearful. And he shall turn the heart of fathers to sons and the heart of sons to their fathers, lest I come and strike the land with utter destruction. (Mal 3:23-24)

[Malachi 3:1, the messenger who prepares the way, names no one. The identification rests on 3:23 within the same book and is carried at that warrant, marked, and not extended further.]

[This sentence is what the missing burial notice makes possible. A prophet with a grave is a closed file. A prophet with a mantle on a riverbank and a failed three-day search is available to be sent again.]

BOX | M STRUCTURAL COMMENT · THE ROOT RETURNS, AND THE LONG AFTERIMAGE

The closure is elegant and unproven. If the gentile at the opening carries any part of the root meaning to turn or return, then the corpus closes on the same consonants it opened with, since the function assigned here is *heshiv*, to turn hearts of fathers to sons and sons to fathers. That root was judged the weakest of the four at the entrance, and it is not strengthened by the elegance of the closure. It is recorded as elegant and unproven.

What this sentence made possible. A prophet with a grave is a closed file. A prophet with a mantle on a riverbank and a failed three-day search is available to be sent again, and this verse converts that absence into a standing expectation. Everything downstream is built on the conversion.

The rabbinic tradition then installed the pending figure into recurring practice, and one instrument deserves naming because it is procedural rather than sentimental. Unresolved legal disputes are set aside with a term meaning let it stand, glossed as standing until Elijah AS comes and rules. That is an appeal court permanently in recess, and it lets a legal system tolerate irreducible disagreement without either forcing a verdict or fracturing. A tradition that had buried its prophet could not have built it. The cup poured and not drunk, and the chair set at every circumcision, install the same pending figure into the domestic and life-cycle calendar.

And the largest gap between record and credit. Latin hermits settled on Mount Carmel in the late twelfth century and received a rule from Albert of Jerusalem early in the thirteenth. The order subsequently developed and defended an origin doctrine tracing its foundation to this prophet and an unbroken succession on the mountain, a claim contested at length in a formal seventeenth-century dispute. Set that against the record, which gives no order, no rule, no habit, no property, no foundation, no school, and no succession beyond a single named disciple. An institution constructed a nine-hundred-year descent from a figure whose defining feature was holding no institution at all.

BOX | N LEDGER

Every unit used, with its match-class, halo function, and sequencing warrant.

1 Kgs 16:29-34 · halo · SETTING · fixed by position. 1 Kgs 17:1 · NAMED · entrance · EXPLICIT by position, no transitional formula. 1 Kgs 17:2-7 · NAMED, ADDRESSED · commission · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 17:8-16 · NAMED, ADDRESSED · commission · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 17:17-24 · NAMED, TITLED · episode · EXPLICIT, *after these things*. 1 Kgs 18:1-2 · NAMED, ADDRESSED · commission · EXPLICIT, *in the third year*. 1 Kgs 18:3-4 · halo · CAUSE · parenthetical. 1 Kgs 18:7-16 · NAMED, TITLED · episode · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 18:17-19 · NAMED · confrontation · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 18:20-40 · NAMED · ordeal · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 18:41-46 · NAMED · consequence · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 19:1-8 · NAMED · flight · EXPLICIT, *by this time tomorrow*. 1 Kgs 19:9-18 · NAMED, ADDRESSED · theophany and commission · EXPLICIT, *forty days*. 1 Kgs 19:19-21 · NAMED · succession · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 21:1-16 · halo · CAUSE · EXPLICIT, *after these things*. 1 Kgs 21:17-29 · NAMED, ADDRESSED · arraignment · EXPLICIT. 1 Kgs 22:34-38 · halo · CONSEQUENCE · EXPLICIT. 2 Kgs 1:2-17 · NAMED, TITLED, ADDRESSED · episode · IMPLIED by reign succession. 2 Kgs 2:1-18 · NAMED, TITLED · departure · EXPLICIT. 2 Kgs 9:36, 10:10, 10:17 · NAMED · fulfilment notice · CONSEQUENCE, after the departure. 2 Chr 21:12-15 · NAMED · UNPLACED, held out of the arc. Mal 3:23-24 · NAMED · FORWARD, outside the life. Mal 3:1 · unnamed · identification fenced, resting on 3:23. Q 6:85 · NAMED · SETTING · parallel branch. Q 37:123-132 · NAMED · vignette · SERIES-FRAME · parallel branch, unsequenced.

BOX | O THE SILENCE MAP

What the corpus does not supply, stated so that no reader fills it.

No birth. No birth notice, no date, no place of birth, and no age at any point in the life.

No lineage. No father, no mother, no tribe, no clan, and no priestly or prophetic house. He is the only major prophetic figure in the corpus introduced without a patronymic. Isaiah AS is given ben Amoz, Jeremiah AS ben Hilkiah, Ezekiel AS ben Buzi, Hosea ben Beer. He is given a town that cannot be located and a region.

No call. This is the largest single silence and it is easily missed because the narrative moves so fast. Every comparable figure receives a commissioning scene: Musa AS at the bush, Isaiah AS in the temple, Jeremiah AS before he was formed, Ezekiel AS by the river, Amos taken from behind the flock. He receives none. He is already speaking in his first verse, and the corpus never says who sent him first or when.

No household. No wife, no children, no house, no land, no property, and no income of any kind. The sustenance is ravens, a destitute foreign widow, and twice an angel with bread.

No interiority formula. The corpus never uses *wayyomer belibbo*, he said in his heart, or any equivalent, of him. The five interior glimpses recorded above are all external: a protest spoken aloud, a petition spoken aloud, a posture with the face between the knees, a request made upon his own *nefesh*, and a self-assessment spoken twice to God. There is no scene anywhere in which the reader is inside him. That absence is a property of the corpus and it is not repaired here.

No duration. The only interval the corpus counts in the whole life is *in the third year*. The gap between Horeb and the vineyard is unmeasured, between the vineyard and Ahaziah unmeasured, between Ahaziah and the departure unmeasured. The widely repeated three and a half years of drought is not in Kings.

No death, no body, no grave. The single most consequential silence. Kings supplies a burial notice as a formula and withholds it exactly once. What stands in its place is a garment on a riverbank and fifty men searching three days without result.

No teaching. Nothing about what he taught the successor, over what period, or where. The relationship is given as a mantle, a refusal to be left, and a request for an inheritance share.

BOX | P CLOSING NOTE

Proportion. Scripture carried verbatim substantially exceeds the connective prose throughout. The commentary is a separate layer: remove every box and the life stands complete and unchanged.

Interiority. Five instances, all of them reported by the text and none supplied: a protest spoken aloud over the widow's son, a petition on the mountain, a posture with the face between the knees, a request made upon his own life under the broom tree, and a self-assessment spoken twice at Horeb. Where a reader most expects an interior scene, at the Kishon, on the road to Beersheba, at the throwing of the mantle, and at the Jordan, the corpus gives none and neither does this account.

The shape of the life. A man with no lineage and no call, who arrives already speaking. A sequence of eleven commissions and four confrontations, each answered and each recorded. A life conducted entirely in public speech and act, transferred at its end by a garment to a man who was ploughing, and terminated by an absence where the corpus's own formula requires a grave.

⌞ GOL